MODULE 3

Module 3: Cuts & Styles

12 techniques · 36 video lessons



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Next step

> *Module 3 is where the fundamentals and fades you have practiced start turning into complete haircuts. Each of the twelve techniques below is written as a step-by-step lesson you can follow with a mannequin head first, and with a live model only when your hands feel steady.*

How to use this module

Read the whole lesson once before you pick up a tool. Then work through the steps in order, pausing after each one to check your work in the mirror from the front, both sides and the back. Every lesson has the same parts: the goal, the tools you need, numbered steps, common mistakes, a practice drill, a safety note, a time estimate and a client-fit note. Pair each written lesson with the curated video lessons from experienced barbers listed for the same technique, because watching hand position and angles in motion is the fastest way to understand them.

Guard numbers in this module

Clipper guards are named by number. A #1 guard leaves hair at 1/8 in (3 mm), a #2 at 1/4 in (6 mm), a #3 at 3/8 in (10 mm) and a #4 at 1/2 in (13 mm), and so on in 1/8 in steps. Open clippers with no guard cut closest. Always confirm the length on the guard itself, since sets can differ slightly.

GUARD	LENGTH (IN)	LENGTH (MM)	TYPICAL USE HERE
#1	1/8	3	Tight sides, fade bottoms
#2	1/4	6	Taper fade and crew sides
#3	3/8	10	Softer sides, upper fade
#4	1/2	13	Blending into a flat top
#6	3/4	19	Longer crew or crop tops

Order of work

1. Consult the client: lifestyle, hair type, growth patterns, how much time they spend styling.
2. Sanitize your hands and tools, drape the client and check the skin for irritation or open sores.
3. Section and cut the structure first (sides, back, perimeter), then the top, then the details.
4. Check balance and symmetry, refine the outline, remove loose hair, and finish with product and a mirror check.

Safety and licensing come first

Disinfect tools between every client, use a fresh single-use blade for every razor service, wash your hands, and know what to do with an accidental nick (stop, apply pressure with clean gauze, follow your local rules for blood exposure). Many places require a barber or cosmetology license to cut hair for pay, so check your local licensing requirements. The Certificate of Completion from this course is not a license.

Practice plan

Spend two or three sessions on each technique with a mannequin before moving on. Photograph your results from four angles and compare them with the reference photos in the bonus library. Slow and accurate beats fast and uneven every time.

About the video lessons

This module lists 36 curated public video lessons from experienced barbers, linked from their original channels. They belong to their creators and links can change over time. Every technique also has complete written steps, so you can follow it without the videos.

#	TECHNIQUE	VIDEOS
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12	Long hair scissor cut	3

1. Razor cut

> *Create a soft, textured, slightly feathered cut by removing weight with a razor instead of cutting blunt lines with shears.*

Estimated practice time: 45 to 60 minutes

Tools you need

- Straight razor or shavette with a fresh single-use blade
- Cutting comb

- Spray bottle
- Sectioning clips
- Cape and neck strip
- Disinfectant and gloves

Step by step

1. Consult the client and check the scalp for irritation, sores or razor-sensitive skin before choosing this technique.
2. Wash hands, put on gloves if your local rules or comfort call for them, and load a brand-new blade. Never reuse a razor blade between clients.
3. Shampoo or dampen the hair thoroughly. Razor cutting needs wet hair that is well lubricated so the blade glides instead of pulling.
4. Comb the hair smooth and section it into top, sides and back, clipping the top out of the way.
5. Start at the nape. Hold a small section between your comb and fingers, keep the blade nearly flat to the hair and slide it in short, light strokes from mid-length toward the ends.
6. Work upward in horizontal sections, keeping the same angle and pressure so the length and texture stay consistent.
7. Move to the sides and over the ears, protecting the ear with your free hand and keeping the blade angle shallow.
8. Release the top section and razor it from the roots outward in light strokes to build movement. Use a steeper angle only on the ends for more feathering.
9. Check the shape: comb everything down, then lift and cross-check sections for uneven spots.
10. Dry the hair, style it and refine any heavy areas with a few more light passes. Dispose of the blade in a sharps container.

Common mistakes

- Cutting dry hair, which tugs and damages the ends.
- Using too steep an angle, which chops the hair too short and frizzes it.
- Pressing hard instead of letting the blade glide.
- Reusing or using a dull blade.
- Razoring right to the roots on thick hair, leaving short spiky patches.

Practice drill

On a wet mannequin, razor one section at a time and compare three blade angles (about 10, 20 and 30 degrees) to see how each changes the texture. Repeat until every stroke looks identical.

Safety note

Single-use blade for every client, discarded in a sharps container. Never cut over broken or irritated skin. If you nick the skin, stop, apply clean gauze with pressure, and follow your local blood-exposure rules.

Client fit

Medium to thick straight or wavy hair needing weight removed; oval, square or round faces. Avoid on very coarse or very curly hair.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Mens Haircut Tutorial | Step By Step Barber Lesson | Plus BONUS Razor Texture Lesson https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=juRA9DdDM_g	The One Minute Barber	Step-by-step men's cut with a bonus lesson on razor texturizing
HOW TO CUT HAIR (FULL TUTORIAL) FULL SHORT TEXTURED RAZOR CUT https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=T5OTkBgvzuE	Erik Lander Education	Full short textured razor cut shown start to finish
Master Classic Razor Cut with MC Barber - No Scissors, All Razor https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9uBw-kopK8c	MC Barber	Classic cut done entirely with a razor, no scissors

2. V-cut

> *Shape the back hairline into a clean V so the neckline looks sharp and tapers to a point at the center of the nape.*

Estimated practice time: 10 to 15 minutes

Tools you need

- Trimmers (T-blade style)
- Clippers with a #1 guard
- Cutting comb
- Neck duster or soft brush
- Small mirror
- Skin-safe neck strip

Step by step

1. Ask the client how they want the back to finish, and check the nape for moles, scars or sensitive skin.
2. Clean and sanitize your trimmers and put a fresh neck strip around the collar.
3. Complete the haircut first, including the clipper work on the sides and back, so the neckline can be balanced against the finished shape.

4. Find the center line of the neck by locating the middle of the spine and the center of the nape. Mark it mentally or with a light comb line.
5. Decide how deep the V will sit. A shallow V at the top of the nape suits shorter growth; a deeper V works when the hair is longer and thicker at the neck.
6. With the trimmers, start at one ear and draw a straight diagonal line down toward the center point, keeping the blade edge steady.
7. Repeat from the opposite ear, meeting at the same center point. Use the same angle on both sides so the V is symmetrical.
8. Clean the sides of the V with light trimmer strokes, working from the bottom up, and remove loose hair with the brush.
9. Show the client the back with the hand mirror, and fine-tune any uneven point or soft edge.
10. Apply a soothing, skin-safe aftershave or cooling product only if the client is comfortable with it.

Common mistakes

- Making the V too deep so it looks pinched.
- Different angles on each side, giving a lopsided point.
- Cutting the V before the haircut is finished.
- Scraping the skin with the trimmer corners.
- Starting too high on the neck.

Practice drill

Practice drawing the V in washable marker on a mannequin neck, then trim it. Repeat until both sides match within 1/16 in.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep the trimmers flat and use only the tips of the blade. Wipe tools with a disinfectant between clients and do not trim over cuts or irritation.

> **Client fit**
>
> Any hair type that grows low on the nape; works especially well with tapered or faded backs and a medium neck length.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How to Cut Men's Hair V Cut | 2021 Barber Tutorial #contrast #curlyhair https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8iJ-Oe1lUMk	Marcella Barbers	Cutting a V-shaped back on a modern contrast style

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
V Shape Low Fade Haircut Barber Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VV6CpJO-iFg	House of Shaves Barbershop	V-shaped back with a low fade, tools listed
The Ultimate Haircut Tutorial with MC: A Complete Walkthrough https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rSUbI9D7LzY	MC Barber	Complete haircut walkthrough covering shaping and finishing

3. Razor part (hard part)

> *Cut a clean, defined line into the hair to create a hard part that stays crisp all day.*

Estimated practice time: 15 to 20 minutes

Tools you need

- Trimmers (zero-gap or T-blade style)
- Cutting comb
- Fine tail comb
- Shavette with a fresh single-use blade (optional)
- Shaving cream or gel
- Disinfectant and gloves

Step by step

1. Consult the client on which side they normally part, then comb the hair in its natural direction with it wet or damp.
2. Find the natural part by pushing the hair forward against its growth. The hair will split where it naturally wants to go; this is your starting guide.
3. Locate the starting point at the top of the forehead, about the width of two fingers above the outer corner of the eyebrow.
4. Draw a straight guide line toward the crown using the tail comb, keeping the line aligned with the head shape rather than a perfectly straight ruler line.
5. Clean and dry the area, then go over the guide line with the trimmers, cutting only a thin line of hair about 1/16 in wide.
6. Check the line from the front, then from above. It should curve slightly with the head and not wander.
7. If you use a razor, apply a thin layer of shaving cream, load a fresh blade and shave the line in light strokes against the grain.
8. Soften the edges of the part by blending the hair on either side with a small comb and clipper over comb.
9. Wipe the area clean and apply a light moisturizer or aftershave.
10. Show the finished part in the mirror and style the hair with a light pomade or cream.

Common mistakes

- Starting the part in the wrong place for the head shape.
- Cutting a line that is too wide or too deep.
- Pressing the trimmers too hard into the skin.
- Drawing a perfectly straight line that ignores the curve of the head.
- Skipping skin prep before a razor pass.

Practice drill

Mark a hard part on a mannequin with a pencil and trim it three times, comparing each result for width and curve.

> **Safety note**
>
> When using a razor, use a fresh single-use blade and lather first. Keep fingers away from the blade edge. Do not razor over irritated or broken skin.

> **Client fit**
>
> Short to medium hair with a visible natural part; suits oval, round and square faces; less suited to very thin hair.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How to Create the Perfect Hard Part in a Men's Haircut https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HbGzEK3rRtA	JataiFeatherRazors	Simple steps for creating a clean, sharp hard part
Classic Side Part with Medium Fade - How To Cut a Hard Part https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rwsuoqeml50	Greg Zorian	Cutting a hard part on a classic side part with medium fade
Haircut Tutorial: How to Cut & Style a Razor Faded Side Part X Uppercut Deluxe Pomade https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=N7KHC6umjpM	Uppercut Deluxe	Cutting, razor shaving and styling a faded side part

4. Burst fade (disguised European mohawk)

> *Create a curved fade that wraps around the ear and fades into a longer back, leaving a mohawk-like shape on top.*

Estimated practice time: 45 to 60 minutes

Tools you need

- Clippers
- Guards #1 to #4

- Cutting comb
- Trimmers
- Texturizing shears
- Spray bottle
- Soft neck brush

Step by step

1. Consult the client on how much length they want on top and how dramatic the fade should be.
2. Section the hair into a top zone, two side zones and a back zone. Clip the top out of the way.
3. Set the fade line in an arc starting above the ear and curving back around to the nape, like a half-circle around the ear.
4. With clippers and a #1 guard, cut from the bottom of the arc upward, rolling the clippers out as you rise.
5. Switch to a #2, then a #3 guard, blending each pass into the one before using a flicking motion.
6. Use the clipper-over-comb method to blend the area around the arc, keeping the arc edge smooth.
7. On the back, keep the length slightly longer than the sides and blend into the arc using the same guards.
8. On top, leave a longer section in the center, usually 3 to 5 in, and cut it to a uniform length using your comb and shears.
9. Check the burst arc from both sides. It should be symmetrical, and the fade should have no visible lines.
10. Clean up the edges with trimmers, brush away loose hair and style the top.

Common mistakes

- Setting the arc too high so the fade looks like a bald circle.
- Different arc shapes on each side.
- Visible lines between guard numbers.
- Cutting the top shorter than the sides.
- Rushing the blend instead of using multiple passes.

Practice drill

Draw the arc on a mannequin with a pencil, then cut the fade in three passes. Photograph the left and right side and compare.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep the clipper blade cool by checking it on the back of your hand. Hold the ear forward with your free hand and keep the blade flat against the head when working around it.

> **Client fit**
>
> Straight, wavy or curly hair at least 3 in on top; suits oval, round and square faces; the arc softens a strong jaw.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Mohawk Burst Fade | Barber Tutorial | Barber How To https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iBM-RazpRLw	TheBarberPhil	Burst fade mohawk with textured top and V-shaped back
BURST FADE MOHAWK HAIRCUT | BARBER TUTORIAL https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WgJj0nIeeYU	AdrinTheBarber	Step-by-step burst fade mohawk with tools listed
MOHAWK BURST FADE | HAIRCUT TUTORIAL | SOUTH OF FRANCE | MOHAWK FADE | STEP BY STEP | DETAILED https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wL2k50CQhv8	MikeWillBlendIt	Detailed step-by-step mohawk burst fade for beginners and veterans

5. Taper fade (American cut)

> *Build a gradual taper from short at the neckline and sideburns to longer on the upper sides and top, leaving the shape clean and classic.*

Estimated practice time: 30 to 40 minutes

Tools you need

- Clippers
- Guards #1 to #4
- Tapering shears or cutting shears
- Cutting comb
- Trimmers
- Neck brush
- Spray bottle

Step by step

1. Consult the client and decide on the top length and how high the taper should reach.
2. Comb the hair smooth and section it, clipping the top out of the way.
3. Start at the nape with a #1 guard and clipper-over-comb or free hand. Cut upward about 1 in, then lift the clippers away from the head in a gentle flicking motion.
4. Move to a #2 guard and blend from 1 in to 2 in above the first pass, again flicking out at the end.
5. Switch to a #3 guard and blend another inch upward, keeping the line between lengths soft.
6. Repeat the same sequence on the sides and around the ears, using the ear fold as a guide for the sideburns.

7. Check the blend with a comb by combing the hair outward and looking for any visible lines. Fix any lines by going over with the lighter guard.
8. Cut the top to the desired length, usually 1 to 3 in. Use shears over comb and check that the sides blend into the top.
9. Trim the neckline and around the ears with trimmers.
10. Brush away loose hair and style the top with a light product.

Common mistakes

- Starting the taper too high on the head.
- Not flicking out at the end of each pass.
- Different heights on each side.
- Skipping the comb check.
- Leaving the top too bulky for the taper.

Practice drill

Cut a taper on a mannequin three times, each with a different taper height, and compare how the shape changes.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep your free hand on the ear to protect it and use steady, slow strokes around the sideburns. Disinfect clippers between clients.

> **Client fit**
>
> Any hair type; the classic taper suits oval, square and oblong faces and works well for professional settings.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How to Do a Perfect Taper Fade | Step-by-Step Barber Tutor https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2aPoSXTCwg0	sepehr barbershop	Step-by-step taper fade from guidelines to blending
How to Do a Taper Fade | Barber Tutorial for Beginners & Pros https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vEs9pBF8r4g	Yass The Barber	Taper fade tutorial for beginners and experienced barbers
HOW TO DO A PERFECT TAPER FADE | Full Step-by-Step Barber Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r2WxfaH54i4	Yass The Barber	Full taper fade covering clipper work and blending

6. Flat top (the Will Smith cut)

> *Cut a clean, level top with a squared-off shape and short, tight sides.*

Estimated practice time: 40 to 50 minutes

Tools you need

- Clippers
- Guards #1 to #4
- Wide-tooth cutting comb
- Flat-top comb or level
- Cutting shears
- Trimmers
- Spray bottle

Step by step

1. Consult the client on how tall the flat top should be and how tight the sides should be. A typical height is 1 to 2 in.
2. Comb the hair straight up with a wide-tooth comb so the hair stands at its full height.
3. Start with the sides: use a #2 guard and clipper over comb, working upward until about 1 in below the top.
4. Blend into the top using a #3 or #4 guard, keeping the line between sides and top soft.
5. Using the flat-top comb, hold it level on top of the head and cut the hair that sticks through the teeth, working from the front to the crown.
6. Move the comb back in rows, checking with the flat-top comb that each row is level with the one before.
7. Square off the corners by combing the hair straight up at the front corners and cutting a clean angle.
8. Check the top from the front, sides and back. It should look level and symmetrical. Lay a comb flat across the top to confirm.
9. Clean up the neckline and sideburns with trimmers, creating sharp edges.
10. Brush away loose hair and finish with a light pomade if desired.

Common mistakes

- Not combing the hair straight up before cutting.
- Uneven height across the top.
- Rounding the corners instead of squaring them.
- Leaving a visible line between the sides and top.
- Going too short and losing the top shape.

Practice drill

Practice the level cut on a mannequin with a flat-top comb, then compare the height at five points across the top with a ruler.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep your comb and clippers steady and avoid pushing the blade into the scalp. Sanitize combs between clients.

> **Client fit**
>
> Thick, coarse, straight or tightly coiled hair that stands up; best on square or oval faces.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How to Cut a Flat Top Haircut | Step-by-Step Barber Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PZ-SwZSnnRA	House of Shaves Barbershop	Step-by-step flat top with clean, level top
Flat Top Tutorial by Slim The Barber https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zniwUieFRaM	Slim The Barber	One barber's complete method for cutting a flat top
Haircut Tutorial: How to Cut and Style a Military Flat Top | Uppercut Deluxe https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=O4sBe6oXO58	Uppercut Deluxe	Cutting and styling a military flat top

7. Crew cut

> *Cut a short, easy-care style with tapered sides and a slightly longer top that is neat and low maintenance.*

Estimated practice time: 20 to 30 minutes

Tools you need

- Clippers
- Guards #1 to #6
- Cutting comb
- Trimmers
- Cutting shears
- Neck brush

Step by step

1. Consult the client on their preferred length. A classic crew cut uses a #2 on the sides and 1 to 2 in on top.

2. Comb the hair smooth and start at the nape with a #2 guard, working upward in smooth strokes.
3. Continue up the sides with the same guard until you reach the temples, then lighten the pressure and flick out.
4. Switch to a #3 or #4 guard to blend into the top, using clipper-over-comb for a smooth transition.
5. Work around the ears with a lighter touch, using your free hand to fold the ear forward.
6. Cut the back to match the sides, tapering gradually at the nape.
7. Cut the top: use clippers with a #6 guard or shears over comb to leave 1 to 2 in, with the front slightly longer.
8. Blend the top into the sides so there is no line. Use a comb to check for any steps or ridges.
9. Trim the neckline in a natural or squared shape, depending on the client.
10. Remove loose hair and apply a light product if the client wants it.

Common mistakes

- Leaving the top too long for a crew cut.
- Skipping the blend between top and sides.
- Cutting the sides too short.
- Uneven neckline.
- Ignoring the client's natural hairline.

Practice drill

Cut three crew cuts on a mannequin: one with a #2 sides, one with a #3, and one with a #4. Compare the shapes and note which suits which head shape.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep the clippers moving to avoid hot spots and check the blade temperature. Disinfect tools before each client.

> **Client fit**
>
> Most hair types; ideal for active clients and those wanting a no-fuss style; flatters oval, square and long faces.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Crew Cut Tutorial with MC Barber | Expert Step-by-Step Guide https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K3hnTHzULgk	MC Barber	Classic crew cut from removing bulk to shaping the hairline
Crew Cut Skin Fade - Barbering Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uBw2rT4YjGc	Mike Taylor Education	Classic crew cut paired with a skin fade

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Men's Short Crew Cut Hair Tutorial using Clippers and Scissors https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=J-bN1wOrG4E	JataiFeatherRazors	Short crew cut using clippers and scissors

8. Textured crop

> *Cut a short, choppy top with a fringe pushed forward, paired with faded or tapered sides.*

Estimated practice time: 35 to 45 minutes

Tools you need

- Clippers
- Guards #1 to #4
- Texturizing shears
- Cutting shears
- Cutting comb
- Trimmers
- Matte paste or clay

Step by step

1. Consult the client on the fringe length and the fade style. A short fringe falls about 1 in above the eyebrows.
2. Section the hair into a top section from the front hairline to the crown, clipped out of the way.
3. Cut the sides and back with a fade or taper, using your preferred guard sequence.
4. Release the top section and comb the hair forward.
5. Cut the fringe first: hold small sections between your fingers and use point cutting with shears, cutting into the hair vertically to create a choppy edge.
6. Work back from the fringe toward the crown, cutting each section a little longer, so the hair has a slight slope.
7. Use texturizing shears on the top to remove bulk, cutting at a 45-degree angle in sections about 1 in apart.
8. Blend the top into the sides with clipper over comb, so the transition is smooth.
9. Check the fringe from the front. It should look even but with a natural, irregular edge. Refine as needed.
10. Apply matte paste or clay to the top, push the fringe forward, and tousle it to show the texture.

Common mistakes

- Cutting the fringe in a straight line instead of point cutting.

- Removing too much bulk with the texturizing shears.
- Leaving the fringe uneven side to side.
- Making the sides too short for the top length.
- Forgetting to check with product in the hair.

Practice drill

Practice point cutting on a mannequin fringe. Try three depths of cut and compare how much texture each creates.

> **Safety note**
> Keep the shears pointed away from the face when cutting the fringe and ask the client to close their eyes. Disinfect shears between clients.

> **Client fit**
> Straight or slightly wavy medium-density hair; flatters oval, heart and long faces; fringe softens a high forehead.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Textured Crop Haircut - BARBER Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dYE24w7I_Ns	3versince	Heavy textured crop with a drop fade and texture detail
Textured Crop Haircut Tutorial | Scissoring Secrets for Clean Results https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wAtqY-kCNNU	CADMEN BARBER ACADEMY	Scissoring and sectioning basics for a clean textured crop
Haircut tutorial: How to Cut and Style Textured Crop with Skin Fade https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UFzIRVQjOMQ	Uppercut Deluxe	Cutting and styling a textured crop with a skin fade

9. Pompadour and quiff

> *Build height and volume on top that sweeps back (pompadour) or up and forward (quiff), with shorter, clean sides.*

Estimated practice time: 45 to 60 minutes

Tools you need

- Clippers
- Guards #1 to #4
- Cutting shears
- Cutting comb

- Blow dryer
- Round or vent brush
- Styling pomade or clay
- Spray bottle

Step by step

1. Consult the client on how much height and sweep they want. A pompadour needs about 4 to 6 in on top; a quiff needs 3 to 4 in.
2. Comb the hair back and decide where the top section starts, usually from the front hairline to just behind the crown.
3. Clip the top section out of the way and cut the sides with a fade or taper. Leave the sides long enough to blend into the top.
4. Release the top section and comb it up and back. Use your shears to cut the length evenly, holding the hair at 90 degrees.
5. For a pompadour, leave the front longest and cut the hair progressively shorter toward the crown.
6. For a quiff, leave the front longest but allow it to fall forward and up.
7. Blend the top into the sides with clipper over comb or shears over comb, avoiding a line.
8. Blow-dry the top with a brush to set the lift, directing the airflow up and back (pompadour) or up and forward (quiff).
9. Apply pomade or clay to the hands and work it through the hair, shaping the front into the desired lift.
10. Check from the front and side, and use a comb to set the final shape.

Common mistakes

- Cutting the top too short to hold height.
- Not blending the sides into the top.
- Using too much product, making the hair look greasy.
- Drying hair in the wrong direction.
- Uneven length across the top.

Practice drill

On a mannequin, practice the 90-degree cut on top and blow-dry it into a pompadour and then a quiff to see the difference.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep the blow dryer moving and at a safe distance from the scalp to avoid burns. Test the heat on your own hand first.

> **Client fit**
>
> Thick straight or wavy hair with enough length; flatters oval, square and round faces; avoid on very fine hair.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
The Quiff haircut tutorial by Russian Barber Andrew Shefer (short pompadour haircut with no fade) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9Wus9WerMH0	Andrew Shefer	Short quiff with scissor-over-comb work and blow-dry volume
How to create Fade pompadour style and Messy Quiff haircut https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Lim_MPjU8ok	Slikhaar TV - Mens hair	One cut styled as a fade pompadour and a messy quiff
How to cut a boy's POMPADOUR or quiff haircut || tutorial with fade, blending & cowlicks https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Di2e9UPDKLI	Rachel's Reviews & Fun Finds	Pompadour with fade, blending and cowlick handling

10. Curly top with a fade

> *Combine a defined, healthy curly top with a clean fade on the sides for contrast.*

Estimated practice time: 45 to 60 minutes

Tools you need

- Clippers
- Guards #1 to #4
- Cutting shears
- Wide-tooth comb
- Spray bottle
- Curl cream or leave-in conditioner
- Diffuser (optional)

Step by step

1. Consult the client about curl type, length and routine. Ask how they normally style their curls.
2. Start with damp curls, not soaked. Wet curls stretch and appear longer than they are.
3. Section the top, clip it out of the way and cut the sides and back with a fade, following your preferred guard sequence.
4. Blend the fade into the top with clipper over comb, leaving enough length at the transition so the curls fall naturally.
5. Release the top section and comb gently with the wide-tooth comb from the ends to the roots.
6. Cut the curls dry or damp, one curl at a time. Pinch each curl at the length you want and snip just below your fingers.

7. Work from the front to the crown, keeping the length consistent and following the natural curl pattern.
8. Refine the shape from the front, sides and back, rounding the edges slightly for a natural look.
9. Apply curl cream to the top, scrunching upward to enhance the curl pattern.
10. Diffuse or air dry, and check that the shape holds.

Common mistakes

- Cutting curls fully stretched and ending up too short.
- Using a fine-tooth comb that breaks the curl pattern.
- Fading too high, leaving the top disconnected.
- Brushing dry curls.
- Over-thinning the curls.

Practice drill

Practice cutting individual curls on a curly practice head or on a willing friend. Compare the curl pattern before and after styling.

> **Safety note**
> Be gentle with combing to avoid pulling on the scalp. Keep shears away from the scalp and disinfect them between clients.

> **Client fit**
> Wavy to tightly coiled hair at least 3 in on top; works for most face shapes.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Curly Top Haircut Skin Fade And Beard https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fPX7TfSQ2Qk	EZBLADESHAVINGPRODUCTS	Curly top with a skin fade on the sides
FULL LENGTH HAIRCUT TUTORIAL: FRESHEST DROP FADE | CURLY TOP https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=145_qaDWp2Q	360Jeezy	Full-length drop fade with curly top for beginners
HAIRCUT TUTORIAL: UNDERCUT CURLY TOP FADE | BEGINNERS AND ADVANCE BARBERS https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WkbYDNSsBsY	Garrick Dixon	Step-by-step undercut curly top fade, clippers listed

11. Line-up and shape-up

> *Define a crisp hairline across the forehead and temples (line-up) and square the edges and sideburns (shape-up) for a sharp finish.*

Estimated practice time: 15 to 25 minutes

Tools you need

- Trimmers (zero-gap or T-blade style)
- Fine tail comb
- Shaving gel or cream
- Shavette with a single-use blade (optional)
- Neck duster
- Cotton pads
- Aftershave or soothing balm

Step by step

1. Consult the client on where they like their hairline and whether they want it natural or squared.
2. Wipe the skin along the hairline with a clean cloth so you can see the natural line clearly.
3. Find the natural hairline by pushing hair forward and noting where it starts to grow.
4. Start at the center of the forehead with the trimmers and draw a gentle line across to each temple, matching the natural curve.
5. Cut the temples by shaping the corners into a defined angle or a soft curve, depending on the client's preference.
6. Use the tail comb to hold the hair back while trimming around the ears and along the sideburns.
7. Square off the sideburns, keeping them the same length and width on both sides.
8. Check the symmetry from the front by looking at both temples at the same time. Adjust as needed.
9. If using a razor, apply a thin layer of shaving gel, load a fresh blade and shave the line lightly, working with the grain first.
10. Wipe away the gel, apply a soothing balm, and brush off any loose hair.

Common mistakes

- Setting the hairline too low or too high.
- Different temple shapes on each side.
- Pushing the trimmer into the skin.
- Removing too much hair and creating gaps.
- Skipping skin prep before a razor pass.

Practice drill

Mark a hairline on a mannequin and trim it three times. Compare the line each time for symmetry using a ruler.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep the trimmer blade flat and use a light touch. Use a fresh blade for every razor service. Do not work over broken skin or on clients with skin conditions you cannot identify.

> **Client fit**
>
> Short to medium hair with a defined hairline; pairs well with fades and tapers; works for all face shapes.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
HOW TO DO A SHAPE UP | LINE UP | EDGE UP on a CLASSIC hairstyle https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IHS2BDLuWUo	David Falla	Edge up, line up and shape up on a classic hairstyle
Professional Barber Explains the RIGHT Way to Shape Up https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Lb4AEinSDwA	SliderCuts (Slider)	Professional step-by-step approach to clean line-ups
How To Edge up | Shape up | Line up | Step By Step https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DUnRnm21SKc	Matt Giftedhands	Step-by-step line-up with pointed sideburns, trimmer used

12. Long hair scissor cut

> *Cut longer hair with shears for a clean, balanced shape that grows out well.*

Estimated practice time: 45 to 75 minutes

Tools you need

- Cutting shears
- Wide-tooth comb
- Fine-tooth comb
- Sectioning clips
- Spray bottle
- Cape and neck strip
- Texturizing shears (optional)

Step by step

1. Consult the client on the desired length, shape and the amount they are willing to remove. Hair longer than the shoulders usually needs a trim of at least 1 in.
2. Wash and towel dry the hair to damp. Detangle gently from the ends to the roots with a wide-tooth comb.
3. Section the hair into four parts: top, two sides and back. Clip each section out of the way.

4. Start at the nape and cut the guide length straight across, holding the hair between your fingers at the desired length.
5. Release the next section and cut to match the guide, working upward in horizontal sections.
6. Move to the sides and cut each to the same guide length, keeping the sections even on both sides.
7. For layers, lift sections at 90 degrees and cut the ends in a straight line. For soft layers, lift at 45 degrees.
8. Use point cutting to soften the ends, cutting into the hair vertically rather than straight across.
9. Check the shape by combing all the hair down and looking at the line from the front and back. Fix any uneven spots.
10. Dry and style the hair, then do a final check, adjusting the shape if needed.

Common mistakes

- Cutting dry tangled hair.
- Taking too much length off at once.
- Uneven sections left and right.
- Cutting at the wrong angle for the layers.
- Forgetting that hair shrinks as it dries.

Practice drill

On a long-hair mannequin, cut a guide length and three levels of layers. Compare each result for balance and shape.

> **Safety note**
>
> Cut with sharp shears and keep your fingers clear of the blades. Hold the hair away from the neck and ears while cutting. Disinfect shears and combs between clients.

> **Client fit**
>
> Medium to thick straight or wavy hair, shoulder length or longer; flatters oval, heart and square faces.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How To Scissor Cut Long Mens Hair | Create Layers and a Perimiter https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4ILx5sUL-Ck	The One Minute Barber	Scissor cutting long hair with layers and a perimeter
How To SCISSOR CUT Men's Hair | Step by Step Tutorial for Beginners https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UkL-JFsY1M0	The One Minute Barber	Beginner-friendly step-by-step scissor cut
How to Scissor Cut Mens Hair | For That Red Carpet Flow https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gLIqfj9xEv4	The One Minute Barber	Natural flowing scissor cut focused on movement

Next step

Practice each technique on a mannequin head until you can repeat it with clean results, then move to the next module.